

Create your own harmony

Here is a two-part harmonization of the melody shown on p.150. For a piano, two chords per measure will keep the harmony interesting; fewer than that and the song may fall flat or sound too plain. Harmonizing every note, however, will rob the song of its simple character. The song has a strong accent on the first beat of the measure, so that is where the harmony should be the strongest. Watch out for overcomplicating the harmony on a weak beat because that will introduce an unwanted stress on the beat.

G doubled in bass and alto for a strong sense of the tonic

C treated as a non-harmony note (a passing or a neighbor note)

Harmony changes at the end of the measure, off the beat, giving the rhythm folk-like lift.

Satisfying expectation by keeping the same harmony for the first half of the phrase

Imperfect cadence on the dominant asks the harmonic question, what next?

▽ **Write your own version**
Several different harmonic solutions will work with simple melodies. Try writing in three parts, or in E minor rather than G major.

Perfect 4-5-1 cadence in G major: G doubled in the bass.

LOOKING CLOSER

How and where?

Most composers, in the past and present, have used a piano to experiment with music. For some pianists, especially the ones who are good in their own right, the piano shapes the harmony of the music even if it is written for other instruments. Beethoven and Stravinsky used the piano to explore a range of ideas.

Tempo giusto ♩ = 50



▽ “Augurs of Spring”

Written for strings, but clearly conceived on the piano, the sound of Stravinsky’s savage ballet “Augurs of Spring” is summed up in these chords. Try them for yourself.